



Sagrada Família

Antoni Gaudí's unfinished, experimental masterwork, a symbol of his love for God and his native Catalonia

The towering spires and immense portals of Barcelona's Sagrada Família (or Expiatory Temple of the Holy Family) skillfully combine elements of Gothic church architecture with the fluid, organic, and personal Art Nouveau style of Antoni Gaudí (1852–1926). Work on the church began in 1882 to a traditional cruciform Neo-Gothic design by Francisco de Paula del Villar but, following disagreements about the project's direction, Gaudí took over as chief architect the following year.

An expression of belief

Gaudí saw the church's construction as an act of faith and devoted his life to the work, even living in a hut on the site. Villar's design soon gave way to Gaudí's extraordinary imagination. Every inch of the structure reflects his love of light, color, and natural forms and

is rich with Christian symbolism. By the time Gaudí died in 1926, killed in a trolley accident outside the church, work was well advanced on the vast Nativity Transept. Adorned with stalactitelike gables and towering cone-shaped spires topped with twisting finials of colored broken tiles, it was unlike anything seen in a church before. In Gaudí's highly experimental central nave, treelike columns hold up a carved canopy of sunflower shapes to create an inner forest. Mass has been held daily since the Sagrada Família was consecrated by Pope Benedict XVI in 2010, and millions visit the site—recognized as a UNESCO World Heritage Site in 2005—each year. Their donations help fund the \$28 million needed each year for ongoing construction work. It is hoped that structural work will finally finish in 2026 and decorative work in 2032.

When **completed**, the Sagrada Família will be the **tallest church building** in the world

▷ COLOR AND LIGHT

Stained-glass windows and painted roof bosses flood Gaudí's extraordinary 148-ft- (45-m-) high nave, among the highest in the world, with color and light.

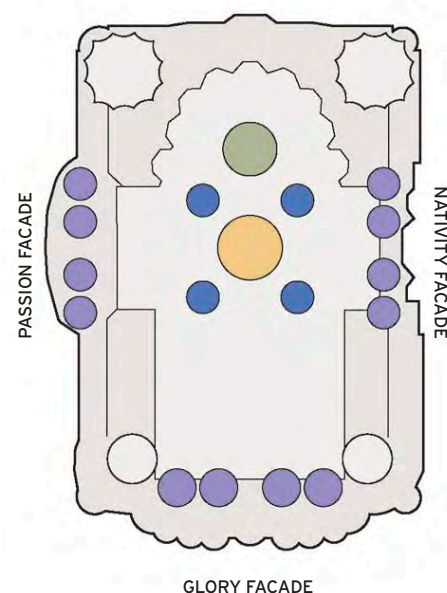
◁ WORK IN PROGRESS

Work on the church has continued nonstop since 1882 and will finally finish in 2032, after 150 years. The vast building site is Spain's most visited tourist attraction.



SPIRES AND SYMBOLISM

Each of the church's 18 spires will represent an important Biblical figure. The tallest tower, almost 590 ft (180m) tall, represents Christ and is flanked by four spires representing the Gospel writers. Mary's spire has a central place in the nave, while the 12 spires for the apostles top the Nativity, Passion, and Glory facades.



KEY

- Christ
- Mary
- Gospel writers
- Apostles



△ SYMBOLS AND SCULPTURE

The distinctive "dripping wax"-style carving of the Nativity Facade combines exotic natural forms with traditional sculpted figures symbolizing Christ's birth.